

Atoms & Nuclear Radiation.

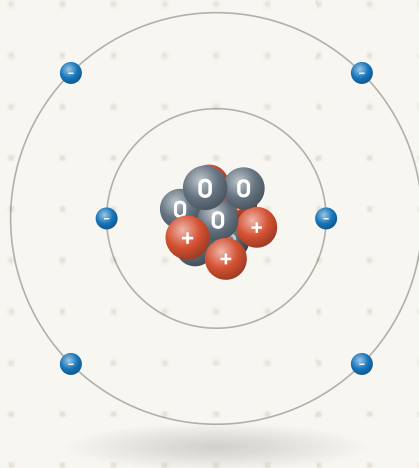
Lesson 04

Energy levels and the nucleus

Neon signs glow red and sodium street lamps glow orange. Each element gives out its own colours of light. What are its electrons doing?

IN THIS LESSON YOU WILL

- describe Bohr's model of electrons in energy levels
- explain how electrons change level when they absorb or emit electromagnetic radiation
- describe how protons and then neutrons were discovered
- explain why scientific models change



NAME

CLASS

TEACHER

TARGET GRADE

How this booklet works.

This is the booklet for **Lesson 4** of the Atoms and Nuclear Radiation unit. It builds on the lessons before it; the “Do now” questions and the quick answers at the back help you check what you remember. Keep it: it is your classwork book *and* your revision guide.



DO NOW

Quick questions from earlier lessons. Remembering again is what makes it stick.



LEARN IT

Explanations, diagrams and worked examples. Read this again when you revise.



TRY IT

Practice that builds up: first with support, then on your own, then a challenge.



LAB

Record what you find in a simulation or a model experiment.



EXAM CORNER

AQA-style questions with a tip on how the marks are given.



REVISE IT

Summary, cover-and-answer questions and an “I can” check to colour in.



Revising at home? (1) Read the Learn it pages. (2) Cover them and answer the “Cover the page” questions in Revise it. (3) Check with the quick answers at the back. (4) Go through the matching slides in the teaching deck, and try the simulations.

● The route through the unit (this lesson is highlighted)

01 Inside the atom

03 From plum pudding to the nucleus

05 Radioactive decay

07 Properties and uses of radiation

09 Half-life calculations

02 Isotopes and ions

04 Energy levels and the nucleus

The Bohr model, absorbing and emitting EM radiation, protons and neutrons, why models change (slides 18–25)

06 Nuclear equations

08 Half-life and random decay

10 Contamination and irradiation

Teaching deck: panphy.app/gcsephy/decks/atoms-and-radiation. Simulations:

panphy.app/simulations/atomic_models.html and panphy.app/simulations/nuclear_decay.html

Energy levels and the nucleus.

AQA Physics 4.4.1.1–4.4.1.3; Combined Science 6.4.1.1–6.4.1.3

BIG QUESTION

Neon signs glow red and sodium street lamps glow orange. Each element gives out its own colours of light. What are its electrons doing?

BY THE END YOU CAN

- describe Bohr's model of electrons in energy levels
- explain how electrons change level when they absorb or emit electromagnetic radiation
- describe how protons and then neutrons were discovered
- explain why scientific models change

Bohr model

energy level

absorb

emit

electromagnetic radiation

proton

neutron

peer review

SLIDES AND SIMULATIONS

Teaching deck, slides 18–25

The Bohr model, energy levels, protons then neutrons, and why models change.

panphy.app/gcsephy/decks/atoms-and-radiation/#18

Atomic Models simulation

panphy.app/simulations/atomic_models.htm



RETRIEVE

Do now

From earlier lessons. No notes!

1

Which experiment showed that atoms have a tiny nucleus?

2

What is the charge on an alpha particle?

3

In the nuclear model, where are the electrons?



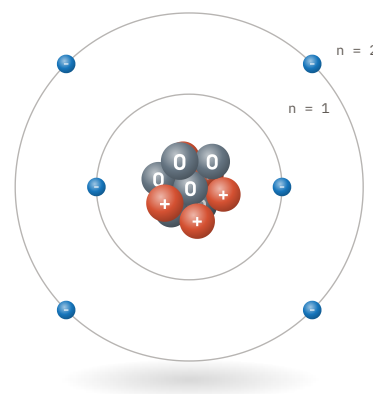
Filling in the details

Bohr's model (1913)

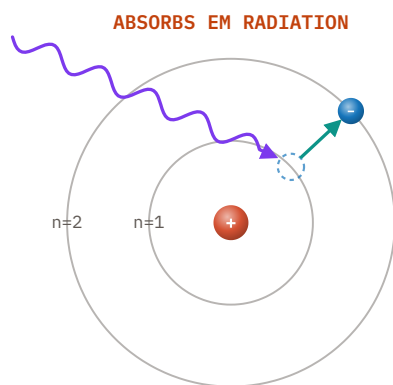
Niels Bohr adapted the nuclear model. He suggested that electrons orbit the nucleus **at specific distances**. Each allowed distance is an **energy level**.

Bohr's theoretical calculations **agreed with experimental observations** of the light given out by atoms. That agreement is why other scientists accepted his model.

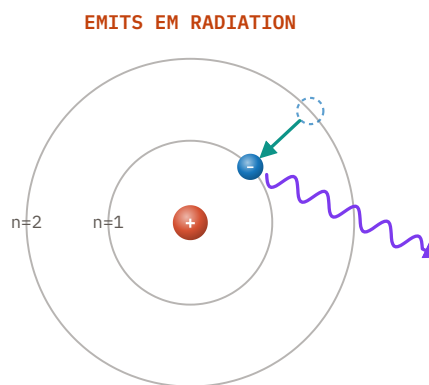
A carbon atom has 2 electrons in the first energy level ($n = 1$) and 4 in the second ($n = 2$).



Electrons can change energy level



moves further out
higher energy level



moves closer in
lower energy level

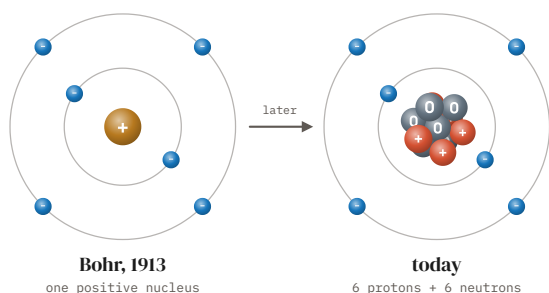
The electron...	Moves...	Energy level
absorbs electromagnetic (EM) radiation	further from the nucleus	higher
emits electromagnetic (EM) radiation	closer to the nucleus	lower

THINK OF A LADDER

An electron can stand on a rung, but not between rungs. To climb up it must take in exactly the right amount of energy; when it drops down, it gives that energy out as EM radiation. This is why each element gives out its own colours of light.

Where the model breaks: the energy levels are not evenly spaced like rungs, and electrons are not little balls standing on them.

● Filling in the nucleus



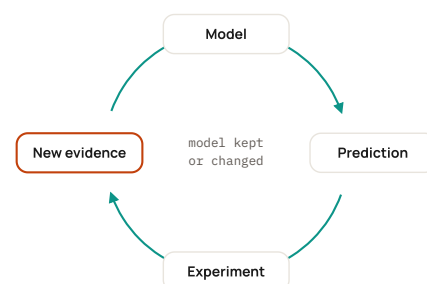
Bohr pictured one positive nucleus. Today we draw its protons and neutrons.

Later experiments (about 1920) showed that the positive charge of a nucleus is made of smaller particles, each with the same positive charge: **protons**.

In 1932 **James Chadwick** gave the experimental evidence for the **neutron**, about 20 years after scientists had accepted that atoms have a nucleus.

● Why models change

- 1 A model must **explain the evidence** we already have.
- 2 It makes **predictions** that experiments can test.
- 3 If new evidence does not fit, the model is **changed or replaced**.
- 4 Results are **published** so other scientists can check them (**peer review**) before a model is accepted.



PRACTISE
Try it

- 1 In each diagram an electron moves between energy levels. Does the atom **absorb** or **emit** EM radiation? Circle one for each.

A

absorbs
emits

B

absorbs
emits

C

absorbs
emits

D

absorbs
emits

- 2 Complete the sentences.

When an electron absorbs electromagnetic radiation, it moves to a _____ energy level, _____ the nucleus. When an electron moves to a lower energy level, it _____ electromagnetic radiation.

WORD BANK

higher

lower

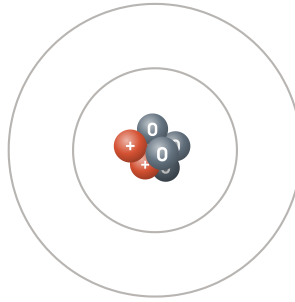
further from

closer to

absorbs

emits

- 3 A lithium atom has 3 electrons: 2 in the first energy level and 1 in the second. Draw the electrons on the diagram.



- 4 **SUPPORTED** Complete the timeline.

Year	Scientist(s)	Discovery or model
1897	J. J. Thomson	
1909–1911		Alpha scattering; the nuclear model
1913	Niels Bohr	
1932		Evidence for the neutron

- 5 Explain why scientists really change models.

Leo

Scientists keep changing the model of the atom because they get bored of the old one.

- 6 **CHALLENGE** Protons were identified around 1920, but the neutron was not found until 1932. Suggest why the neutron was harder to find.



Get the marks: Use the key words: absorb/emit, higher/lower energy level, further from/closer to the nucleus.

- 7 Describe how the arrangement of the electrons in an atom may change when the atom absorbs electromagnetic radiation. [2 marks]

- 8 Explain why Bohr's model of the atom was accepted by other scientists. [2 marks]

- 9 Give the name of the scientist who provided the evidence for neutrons. [1 mark]

**SUMMARY**

- Bohr (1913): electrons orbit at specific distances, called energy levels. His calculations agreed with experiments.
- Absorb EM radiation → electron moves to a higher level, further from the nucleus.
- Emit EM radiation → electron moves to a lower level, closer to the nucleus.
- Protons were identified later (about 1920); James Chadwick gave evidence for neutrons (1932).
- New evidence changes models; results are published and peer reviewed.

COVER THE PAGE AND ANSWER

1 What did Bohr add to the nuclear model?

3 Who gave the evidence for the neutron?

2 What happens when an electron emits EM radiation?

4 Why are scientific results published?

I CAN...

describe Bohr's model of the atom



explain what happens when electrons absorb or emit EM radiation



describe the discovery of protons and neutrons



explain why models of the atom have changed



Toolkit.

The facts and methods you have met so far. Learn these: exam questions expect you to recall them without a data sheet.

The three particles

Lesson 1

Particle	Charge	Mass	Where
Proton	+1	1	nucleus
Neutron	0	1	nucleus
Electron	-1	very small	energy levels

Reading the symbol

Lesson 1

$${}^A_Z\text{X e.g. } {}^{23}_{11}\text{Na}$$

- Z, atomic number = protons
- A, mass number = protons + neutrons
- neutrons = A - Z; in an atom, electrons = Z
- Atom radius $\approx 1 \times 10^{-10}$ m; nucleus radius $< 1/10\,000$ of that

Isotopes and ions

Lesson 2

- **Isotopes**: same number of protons, different numbers of neutrons.
- **Positive ion**: an atom that has lost one or more outer electrons. The nucleus is unchanged.

Alpha scattering

Lesson 3

Observation	Conclusion
most straight through	mostly empty space
some deflected	positive centre
a very few bounced back	mass in a tiny centre

Models and energy levels

Lesson 4

- 1897 electron → 1904 plum pudding → 1911 nuclear → 1913 Bohr → 1932 neutron (Chadwick)
- **Absorb** EM radiation → higher level, further out.
- **Emit** EM radiation → lower level, closer in.

REFERENCE

Key words from this lesson.

Learn the meaning and spelling. In exams, precise words earn marks: say “nucleus”, not “middle”, and “unstable nucleus”, not “unstable atom”.

Absorb: Take in energy. An electron that absorbs EM radiation moves to a higher energy level.

Bohr model: Electrons orbit the nucleus at specific distances, called energy levels (1913).

Emit: Give out. An electron that moves to a lower energy level emits EM radiation.

Energy level: A specific distance from the nucleus at which electrons are found.

Peer review: Checking of published findings by other scientists.

CHECK YOURSELF

Quick answers.

Answers to the “Do now” and “Cover the page” questions, so you can check yourself when revising. Answers to the longer questions are in the answer edition.

DO NOW

1. The alpha scattering experiment.
2. Positive (+2).
3. Outside the nucleus.

COVER THE PAGE

1. Electrons orbit at specific distances (energy levels).
2. It moves to a lower energy level, closer to the nucleus.
3. James Chadwick (1932).
4. So other scientists can check them (peer review).